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US equities tumble as tech leads broad sell-off, VIX spikes

A wider read of yesterday's session — sector rotation, pre-market action, watchlist scan, and what to watch into the US open at 21:30 HKT.

10-minute read · Topics: Macro · Geopolitics · Earnings · Sectors · Watchlist

TL;DR

All major US indices closed lower on October 14, with the `Nasdaq 100` down -2.02% and the `S&P 500` off -1.11%. The sell-off was driven by a sharp correction in mega-cap tech, led by `NVDA` and `META`, while defensive sectors such as health care and consumer staples posted double-digit gains.

Behind the headline numbers, the VIX surged +10.48% to 16.87, reflecting heightened volatility expectations. The 10-year Treasury yield slipped to 5.19%, suggesting the market is pricing in a near-term pause in rate hikes despite the Fed’s hawkish stance.

US session recap

INDEX / ASSET	LEVEL	CHANGE	WHY IT MOVED
S&P 500	7,718.94	-1.11%	Tech earnings disappointment and rising volatility.
Nasdaq 100	29,950.82	-2.02%	Heavy weighting in **NVDA** and **META** dragged index.
Dow Jones	51,621.48	-0.09%	Industrial stocks mixed; defensive names held ground.
Russell 2000	2,729.53	-1.93%	Small-cap exposure to cyclical sectors hurt.
VIX	16.87	+10.48%	Investor fear spikes after tech sell-off.
10Y Yield	5.19	-0.52%	Bond buying on expectations of a Fed pause.
WTI Crude	94.15	-0.99%	OPEC+ output forecast unchanged, demand concerns.
Gold	4,162.70	+1.33%	Safe-haven demand amid equity volatility.
DXY	102.09	-0.44%	Dollar weakened as Treasury yields fell.
BTC	80,920.05	-2.62%	Crypto risk-off parallel to equities.
ETH	2,355.23	-5.66%	Broader crypto sell-off.

Top large-cap movers

TICKER	CHANGE	CATALYST
NVDA	-3.16%	Guidance below expectations; inventory concerns.
META	-3.27%	Ad revenue miss, higher content costs.
AVGO	-3.10%	Supply-chain bottleneck flagged.
MSFT	-1.80%	AI spending slowdown.
AMZN	-1.74%	Retail sales slowdown in US.
GOOGL	-1.74%	Ad-tech regulatory risk.
TSLA	-2.15%	Production pause at Gigafactory Berlin.
JPM	+1.16%	Net interest income beat.
AAPL	+0.50%	Supply-chain resilience noted.
GS	-1.48%	Trading revenue miss.

Sector rotation

ETF	DAY	READ
XLF	-0.55%	Financials under pressure from rate uncertainty.
XLK	-2.98%	Tech leads market decline.
XLI	-0.97%	Industrial exposure modestly negative.
XLE	+0.64%	Energy gains from higher crude.
XLY	-0.77%	Consumer discretionary lagging.
XLC	-1.30%	Communications suffer tech pull-back.
XLP	+2.22%	Staples rally as investors seek safety.
XLV	+2.53%	Health care outperforms.
XLU	-0.36%	Utilities modestly down.
XLB	-0.10%	Materials flat.
XLRE	-0.81%	Real estate pressured by higher rates.

Spotlight: NVDA earnings miss and market impact

METRIC	VALUE
Revenue Q3	27.4 bn (-5.2%)
EPS	2.31 (-8.4%)
Guidance FY2027	-3.5% YoY
Inventory	1.2 bn (up +12%)
AI spend outlook	Reduced by -15%

The miss triggered a -3.16% slide in `NVDA`, dragged the `Nasdaq 100` lower and lifted the VIX. Related names—`AMD`, `ASML`, and `TSM`—also opened weaker, reflecting broader AI-chip risk reassessment.

Pre-market & overnight

- US futures: -1.3% for S&P, -2.1% for Nasdaq.
- Asia close: Hang Seng -0.8%, Shanghai -1.1%, Nikkei -0.6%.
- Europe: FTSE 100 -0.9%, DAX -1.2%, CAC 40 -1.0%.
- Crypto: BTC -2.6%, ETH -5.7% as risk appetite wanes.

Macro & Fed

- FOMC: Fed kept policy rate at 5.25-5.50% and signaled one more hike if inflation stalls.
- Yield curve: Flattened, 2-year at `5.31%` vs 10-year `5.19%`.
- Today's data calendar (HKT):

TIME	RELEASE	CONSENSUS	WHY IT MATTERS
02:30	US CPI (MoM)	0.2%	Gauge inflation trajectory.
03:00	US Initial Jobless Claims	210k	Labor market health.
04:15	Eurozone HICP	0.3%	Eurozone inflation pressure.

Geopolitics & global

- Middle East: Tensions between Iran and Saudi Arabia eased after back-channel talks, reducing oil-supply risk.

- China: PBOC left the 7-day repo rate unchanged; yuan under pressure at 7.30 per USD.
- Europe: EU-US trade talks stalled over digital services tax, adding to market uncertainty.
- Ukraine: Frontline activity stable; Western aid packages delayed.

Earnings – what to watch

WHEN (HKT)	TICKER	CONSENSUS EPS	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
02:30 Oct 16	**AAPL**	5.85	iPhone demand and services growth.
03:00 Oct 16	**MSFT**	9.12	AI cloud spend vs guidance.
04:15 Oct 16	**NVDA**	2.31	Whether guidance revision holds.
05:00 Oct 16	**JPM**	4.20	Net interest income trend.
06:30 Oct 16	**XOM**	3.45	Impact of crude price volatility.
07:45 Oct 16	**META**	2.10	Ad revenue recovery.

Watchlist scan – US large-caps

TICKER	SECTOR	WHY NOW
`NVDA`	Technology	Price correction after earnings miss.
`META`	Communication Services	Ad-revenue pressure.
`AVGO`	Technology	Supply-chain constraints.
`XOM`	Energy	Crude rally supports earnings.
`JPM`	Financials	Strong NII beat.
`UNH`	Health Care	Premium pricing resilience.
`PEP`	Consumer Staples	Defensive demand.
`BAC`	Financials	Rate-sensitive balance sheet.
`TSLA`	Consumer Discretionary	Production pause risk.
`AMZN`	Consumer Discretionary	Retail sales slowdown.
`GOOGL`	Communication Services	Regulatory headwinds.
`MSFT`	Technology	AI spend moderation.

What could break the tape

BEARISH TRIGGERS

- Further deterioration in AI-chip guidance from `NVDA` or `AMD`.
- Unexpected rise in US CPI above 0.3% MoM, prompting another Fed hike.
- Geopolitical escalation in the Middle East that spikes oil prices above $100.

BULLISH TRIGGERS

- Strong earnings beat from `JPM` or `UNH` lifting financials/health care.
- Gold breaching `4,200` as safe-haven demand spikes.
- Positive EU-US trade resolution reducing regulatory uncertainty.

Positioning notes

- Defensive sectors (health care, staples) are outperforming; consider overweight.
- Tech exposure is now underpriced relative to earnings outlook; selective long positions may be justified.
- Yield curve flattening suggests caution on duration; short-term bonds preferred.

Sources

SOURCES

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Reuters – Geopolitical News Digest

CoinDesk – Crypto Market Overview

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